

Topic:
Concept of good and evil in Islam
Principles of morality

Islam is a complete code of life revealed by Allah to the last of His messengers Muhammad(S.A.W) to guide His slaves (mankind and jinn) to the success in life and afterlife. According to the divine scripture Al-Quran, it is the true religion with Allah the Exalted and the final and complete version of the divine guidance. ***“Let there be no compulsion in religion. Truth stands out clear from error.”(Baqarah 02:256).***

Concept of good and evil in Islam:

As humans, our definitions of good and evil are based on our perceptions and thinking. Human experience however, is limited in many ways. Many things and events which at first appear to be good may prove in the final outcome to be evil, and vice versa. True knowledge is something which is not subject to limitations it is only with God. The Qur'an clearly states that God is the only authority in defining good and evil. Therefore our perceptions of good and evil may be misleading: “. . . ***but it is possible that you dislike a thing which is good for you, and that you love a thing which is bad for you. But God knows, and you know not”.*** (Baqarah 2:216) The Islamic definitions of good and evil are based on the purposes of creation and the meaning of human life. As mentioned above, the ultimate goal of human life is to become perfected spiritually through belief in God (iman), the knowledge of God (marifatullah), the love of God (mahabbatullah), and the worship of God (ibada). Accordingly, whatever brings a person closer to God and will benefit him in the Next World is good, and whatever takes a person away from God, and thus incurs His anger is evil. Extrapolating from these definitions, one can see that those things and events that we perceive as evil may in reality be good, if they lead us closer to God. For instance, a disease may be perceived as evil. But a person who goes through the disease with patience grows spiritually and becomes closer to God. ***“No calamity strikes except by God’s permission”.*** (Taghabun 64:11) Wealth and health may be perceived as good. But if they lead a person to indulge in worldly desires and forget God, then they become evil for that person. ***“Have you seen the one who takes his desires as his god?”*** (Furqan 25:43) The following verse from the Qur'an exemplifies good and evil as they relate to the conduct of our lives: ***“It is not righteousness that you turn your faces toward the East and the West, but righteousness is this that one should believe in God and the last day and the angels and the Book and the prophets, and give away wealth out of love for Him to the near of kin and the orphans and the needy and the wayfarer and the beggars and for (the emancipation of) the captives, and keep up prayer and pay the poor-rate; and the performers of their promise when they make a promise, and the patient in distress and affliction and in time of conflicts-these are they who are true (to themselves) and these are they who guard (against evil)”.*** (Baqarah 2:177)

An inclination toward good and a dislike for evil is inherent in every human being. Prophet Muhammad teaches that good is the beautiful personality and beautiful virtues of a person, while evil is what makes one's heart uncomfortable, unhappy, and is that side of a person that they do not want anyone to know about. Islam teaches that good deeds in this world are like

seeds that will be harvested in the Hereafter: ***“Then shall anyone who has done an atom’s-weight of good, see it!” (Zilzal 99:7)***

Also the Prophet said: ***“Save yourself from the Fire, even by giving half a date in charity, and if you do not find (half a date), then by saying a good word.”*** Good will be rewarded sooner or later. ***“God is never unjust in the least degree: If there is any good (done), He doubles it, and gives from His own presence a great reward”.***(Nisa 4:40) Doing good deeds results from an intention and motivation that causes the action, and therein lies its value. A seemingly good action, if done for reasons other than pleasing God, may not be valued by God as a good deed and may not contribute to that person’s rising to the stations of spirituality. Belief in God should be strongly located in the heart of a person when doing good deeds. Good and evil are intricate concepts that are difficult to define without reference to some sound sources. The revealed scriptures, messengers of God and the human inner conscience provide us with the knowledge of good and evil, as well as giving us information on how to attain good and prevent evil. So human beings should do good deeds and refrain from evil to get the pleasure of Allah.

Principles of morality:

The word “morality” comes from the Latin word *moralitas* meaning “manner, character, and proper behavior”. Morality generally refers to the way of life that an individual, group or society holds as an authority.

The basic principles of morality include obedience of what Almighty Allah and his messenger Muhammad (SAW) has commanded through Quran and Sunnah. If Islam restricts to do something then one should be cautious and refrain from it. Ethics are given immense importance in Islam as Almighty Allah himself says in Holy Qur'an ; "Every soul will be held responsible for what it had done". Moreover, Islam regards morality this much that even a man's worships are disregard in return of a poor behavior or dealing. As the Holy Prophet (PBUH) said "O Allah, grant me high ethics, nobody but you can grant high ethics. O Allah, keep me away from bad qualities." and "There is nothing heavier than high ethics in the mizan (balance) of a believer in the Day of Judgment".

Among the most prominent moral values highly emphasized by Islam is that all Muslims should have the ability to forgive each other for their mistakes. Throughout the Quran, Allah(swt) makes it evident that he is the most forgiving–

“If anyone does evil or wrongs his own soul but afterwards seeks God’s forgiveness, he will find God Oft-forgiving, Most Merciful”. Surah An Nissa: 110

–and Allah's forgiveness is amongst the most repeated topics in the Quran, but an equally important topic is of a person's forgiveness of another.

“And the retribution for an evil act is an evil one like it, but whoever pardons and makes reconciliation – his reward is [due] from Allah. Indeed, He does not like wrongdoers.” (Quran 42:40)

“We have not created the heavens and the earth and everything in between except for a purpose. And the Hour is certain to come, so forgive graciously.” (Quran 15:85)

Here, Allah points out the benefits of reconciliation so as to convince the Muslims to be forbearing and patient towards each other. Compassion towards one another is also a trait of a Muslim society.

Muhammad is the messenger of Allah; and those who are with him are strong against Unbelievers, (but) compassionate amongst each other. (48:29)

Thus, Islam lays out forgiveness as a necessary aspect for a society to be Islamic. However, Quran is clear about the importance of Muslims taking action to "enjoin what is good and forbid what is wrong. A famous hadith quotes the Islamic prophet Muhammad as saying: "Whoever amongst you sees an evil, he must change it with his hand. If he is not able to do so, then with his tongue. And if he is not able to do so, then with his heart, and that is the weakest form of faith".

Collective morality is expressed in the Qur'an in such terms as **equality, justice, fairness, brotherhood, mercy, compassion, solidarity, and freedom of choice.** The preservation of a social order depends on each and every member of that society freely adhering to the same moral principles and practices. Islam, founded on individual and collective morality and responsibility, introduced a social revolution in the context in which it was first revealed. Collective morality is expressed in the Qur'an in such terms as equality, justice, fairness, brotherhood, mercy, compassion, solidarity, and freedom of choice. Leaders are responsible for the application of these principles and are accountable to God and man for their administration. It is reported that a man went to Umar, the second khalifa, to talk to him. It was nighttime, and a candle burned on Umar's desk. Umar asked the man if what he wanted to discuss was personal. The man said that it was, and Umar extinguished the candle so as not to burn public funds for a private purpose. Leaders in Islam, whether heads of state or heads of family or private enterprise, have a higher burden or responsibility than others. There is a relation in Islam between individual responsibility and the rights and privileges derived from membership in the community. Individual obligations must be met before one can claim a portion from the community of which he is part. Each member of a society must fulfill his own obligations and rely on others to fulfill theirs before that society can acquire the necessary reservoir of social rights and privileges which can then be shared by all. The notions of brotherhood and solidarity not only impose upon the community the duty to care for its members, but also require each person to use his initiative to carry out individual and social responsibilities according to his ability.

"And to be firm and patient, in pain (or suffering) and adversity, And throughout all periods of panic. Such are the people of truth, the God-fearing."

Qur'an 2:177

The equality of all Muslims is emphasized repeatedly throughout the Qur'an. It is because of that concept that Islam under the Sunni tradition does not have an ordained clergy. There is a direct relationship between every man and his Creator, and there can be no intermediary. This particular closeness between the individual and God is paramount in belief as well as in practice.

So as a Muslim we should be humble to others and always asks for the forgiveness of Allah because He is the most merciful.

Foundational beliefs:-

Moral principles are the foundational beliefs on which moral standards and behaviors rest. They include beliefs such as the right of all people to equality and justice under the law, the rule of reciprocity, the Golden Rule, and the duty of protecting the weak and vulnerable.

What are moral principles?

Moral principles are guidelines that people live by to make sure they are doing the right thing. These include things like honesty, fairness, and equality. Moral principles can be different for everyone because they depend on how a person was raised and what is important to them in life.

History of Moral Principles

The history of moral principles dates back to Ancient Greece and Ancient China. Moral principles were important in these societies because they believed that to be successful, people needed a clear sense of right and wrong.

Research on moral principles began with Ancient Greek philosophers like Aristotle who wanted to figure out the meaning of virtue. Later, moral principles were studied by philosophers like John Locke, Jean-Jacques Rousseau, and Immanuel Kant.

In the field of psychology, moral principles have been studied in the context of moral development. Psychologists have been interested to understand how children develop a sense of morality and how moral principles are applied in different contexts. ***In the contemporary world, moral principles still play an important role. They are considered guidelines for living life successfully. For example, honesty is considered a moral principle because it keeps relationships strong.***

Types of Moral Principles

There are two types of moral principles: absolute and relative. Absolute principles are unchanging and universal. Relative moral principles change depending on the situation.

Absolute Moral Principles

Absolute moral principles are based on universal truths about the nature of human beings. For example, murder is wrong because it goes against the natural order of things. These are also sometimes called normative moral principles, or those that are generally accepted by society. Below are some examples of absolute moral principles:

- Don't kill.
- Speak the truth.
- Be careful with what you say and do to others.
- Respect the property of others.
- Treat people in need or distress as we would want to be treated if our situation were reversed.

Relative Moral Principles

Relative moral principles are based on opinions and circumstances that may change over time or from person to person or for different situations. Relative moral principles depend on a person's beliefs. Relativism to what people perceive as good or bad in relation to themselves. In other words, when someone says something is good, in most cases they are really saying it is good for them, or perhaps it contributes to their well-being. Below are some examples of relative moral principles

- It is morally wrong to spend money on luxury items
- It is morally right to care for our planet and preserve it for future generations.

How to Adhere to Moral Principles

Many people strive to live by the moral principles they believe in. But, it can be difficult to follow them all of the time, which is what makes following one's own personal moral values even more valuable.

There are many ways that a person might adhere to their moral principles: through thoughts and feelings, actions, or words. Below are some examples.

- *In thoughts and feelings, a person might strive to be honest by being fair and kind.*
- *With actions, a person might live up to their moral principles by not being violent or aggressive.*
- *In words, someone might observe their moral principles through politeness.*

Impact of Moral Principles

Moral principles are important for society because they help people learn how to get along and live well with each other. They teach us that all human beings deserve the same rights, which is why it's not okay to discriminate against someone based on their ethnicity or race. People who follow moral principles also tend to have a better quality of life than those who don't.

Moral principles can also impact an individual's identity and sense of self-worth. For example, someone who is honest may feel that they are a good person because they follow the moral principle to be truthful at all times. And for people with strong values about equality, it might make them feel better about themselves when they don't discriminate against people who are different from them.

Tips to Develop Good Moral Principles

There are various ways to develop moral principles that transcend culture,² religion, and country. If you are just starting on your moral journey, you might consider exploring morals in various philosophical texts.

However, there are also many practical steps a person can take to develop good moral principles:

- *Think about what you would do when faced with an ethical dilemma and why you would make those decisions.*
- *Ask yourself what you think is right or wrong and make sure that your actions are in line with those thoughts.*
- *Watch out for double standards, like being nice to one person while not being so kind to another.*

- If it helps, write down a list of moral principles and post them where they're easy to see, like on a mirror or in your workspace.
- Don't worry if you're not perfectly adhering to your moral principles. The important thing is that you are trying your best.

Pitfalls of Moral Principles:-

There are some things that can go wrong when following moral principles. Below are some examples of how moral principles may not always guide you toward the best course of action.

First, it's possible to make judgments about others based on your personal values and not theirs. For example, if you think all women should dress conservatively because you believe dressing another way is immoral, then you are passing judgment on others based on your own set of standards.

In addition, it can be hard to tell the difference between a moral principle and something that's cultural or part of your upbringing. For example, you might believe women should defer to their husbands because in your culture everyone has traditionally agreed with this idea for generations; however, if you were born into a different country where people don't think this way, you might not feel that it's morally right.

Finally, sometimes people can use moral principles to justify bad behavior like stealing or hurting others in some way. For example, if you steal because you believe it will help the poor, then your thoughts could be twisted to say that stealing is OK.

A Word From Verywell

In general, moral principles are beneficial both to society and the individual person. However, blindly following moral principles without considering their origin or using your judgment based on the situation can be problematic. The best course of action is usually to adhere to a loosely defined set of moral principles that align with your beliefs and society as a whole but to also consider each situation individually and weigh the cost of adhering to your morals in terms of its impact on other individuals.

